

The Great Wall of China

The largest military structure in the world stretches some 6,500 kilometres (4,000 miles) from Shanhaiguan in the east to Jiayuguan in the west. The Great Wall is an amalgam of ancient walls from over 20 states and dynasties, first united into a single defensive system in 214 BCE under the rule of Emperor Qin Shi Huang (260–210 BCE), and later rebuilt three more times to protect against invasion. Varying in height from 6 to 10 metres (20 to 33 ft), the wall has an average depth of 6.5 metres (21 ft) at its base, tapered to 5.8 metres (19 ft) at the top.

Original local materials included stone, brick, rammed earth and wood, but the third rebuilding of the wall (from the ascent of the Ming dynasty in 1368 through to its conclusion in 1644) was stronger and more complex than any of the others. The eastern half is built of dressed stone or kiln-fired brick, the western half of rammed earth, sometimes faced with sun-dried brick. Watchtowers, gateways and forts along the length of the wall guarded against approaching raiders.

